

German — Complete Notes

Everything covered so far, in study format

Rebuilt 2026-09-19

Contents

German — Complete Notes	2
PART I — THE FOUNDATION	3
1.1 The two verbs everything is built on	3
1.2 Two ways to say how you feel — never mixed	3
1.3 Capitalization is grammar, not decoration	3
1.4 sie, Sie, and Sie	4
PART II — ARTICLES, GENDER, AND CASE	4
2.1 The table everything else depends on	4
2.2 What the cases actually mark	4
2.3 When to use accusative	5
2.4 Dative arrives by two separate routes	5
2.5 Verbs that take dative and nothing else	5
PART III — PRONOUNS	6
3.1 The full table	6
3.2 The three jobs of “ihr”	6
3.3 The pronoun trap worth real attention	6
3.4 Possessives use the same endings	7
3.5 uns versus unser-	7
PART IV — NEGATION	8
4.1 Choosing between nicht and kein	8
4.2 Why “kein den Hund” cannot exist	8
4.3 Where nicht goes	8
4.4 keine Zeit versus nicht viel Zeit	9
PART V — PREPOSITIONS	9
5.1 Prepositions that always take dative	9
5.2 Prepositions that always take accusative	9
5.3 Two-way prepositions	10
5.4 nach versus zu	10
5.5 aus versus von — two kinds of “from”	11
5.6 Fixed phrases that ignore the rules	11
PART VI — WORD ORDER	11
6.1 Verb-second — the backbone	11
6.2 Yes/no questions — verb first	11

6.3 W-questions — question word first, verb second	11
6.4 weil sends the verb to the end — and the main clause still needs V2	12
6.5 Time — Manner — Place	12
6.6 Separable verbs	12
PART VII — BEYOND THE PRESENT TENSE	12
7.1 Modal verbs	12
7.2 The imperative	13
7.3 Perfekt — the past tense of conversation	13
7.4 Stem-changing verbs in the present	15
7.5 leben versus wohnen	15
7.6 mögen versus gern	15
7.7 geben — the double-object verb	15
PART VIII — VOCABULARY	15
8.1 Greetings and everyday phrases	15
8.2 People and family	16
8.3 Food and drink	16
8.4 House and rooms	16
8.5 Getting around town	16
8.6 Time and daily routine	16
8.7 Weather	16
8.8 Hobbies	17
8.9 Clothing and colours	17
8.10 Shopping and money	17
8.11 Adjectives and adverbs	17
8.12 Question words	17
8.13 Conjunctions	17
8.14 Numbers 1–20	17
PART IX — THE TRAPS	17
9.1 Traps created by English	17
9.2 Traps created by over-applying a real rule	18
9.3 Plausible rules that are simply false	18
9.4 Small forms that are easy to lose	18
9.5 Words that sit too close together	18
9.6 Where errors actually come from	19
PART X — HOW TO STUDY THIS	19
10.1 Memory hooks	19
10.2 Principles worth following	19
10.3 Writing and speaking test different things	19
10.4 What to work on next	20
QUICK REFERENCE	20

German — Complete Notes

Everything covered so far, written to be studied rather than skimmed.

Parts I–VII are grammar, VIII is vocabulary, IX is the traps that catch people most often, X is method. The quick-reference card at the back is the thing to glance at before an exercise.

Kept in sync with the rest of the repo — see the note at the end.

PART I — THE FOUNDATION

1.1 The two verbs everything is built on

sein — to be. Irregular; there is no pattern to derive, it just has to be known cold.

ich bin	wir sind
du bist	ihr seid
er/sie/es ist	sie/Sie sind

haben — to have. Regular except the du and er forms.

ich habe	wir haben
du hast	ihr habt
er/sie/es hat	sie/Sie haben

These two carry more weight than any other verbs in the language. Beyond their own meanings, **haben** and **sein** are what build the past tense later (Part VII), so time spent making them automatic pays twice.

The slip to watch: *du* takes **hast** and **bist** — never the unchanged forms *haben/sein*.
“Was hast du?”, not “Was haben du?”

1.2 Two ways to say how you feel — never mixed

German has two constructions for states like hunger and tiredness, and they cannot be combined:

- **sein + adjective** — Ich **bin** hungrig. / Ich **bin** müde.
- **haben + noun** — Ich **habe** Hunger. / Ich **habe** Durst.

English “I am hungry” maps onto the first pattern, which makes it the natural default. The second is equally correct but needs the noun form.

Wrong: *Ich habe hungrig* — this mixes the two patterns. Either *bin hungrig* or *habe Hunger*, never a hybrid.

1.3 Capitalization is grammar, not decoration

Every German noun is capitalized, wherever it appears in the sentence: das Buch, die Katze, der Hunger, die Zeit.

But **infinitives and separable prefixes stay lowercase** — unless the word has genuinely been turned into a noun:

lowercase (verb)	capitalized (noun)
Ich sehe fern .	das Fernsehen (television)
Ich kann schwimmen .	das Schwimmen (swimming, the activity)

The distinction is real: *fern* is a prefix doing verb work, *Fernsehen* is a thing. Same letters, different jobs.

1.4 sie, sie, and Sie

Three words, spelled almost identically, told apart by capitalization and by the verb:

Form	Meaning	Verb
sie	she	sie ist
sie	they	sie sind
Sie (<i>always capital</i>)	you (formal)	Sie sind

Mid-sentence, the capital is the only visible difference:

- “Die Frau ist glücklich, denn **sie** hat ein Buch.” — *she*
- “**Sie** haben ein Buch.” — *you*, formal

And **ihr** is never formal. It is informal plural “you all” only — for friends, family, a group of kids. Formal address is always **Sie + sind**, whether you are talking to one person or twenty.

PART II — ARTICLES, GENDER, AND CASE

2.1 The table everything else depends on

	der-word	die-word	das-word	plural
Nominative — subject	der	die	das	die
Accusative — direct object	den	die	das	die
Dative — indirect object	dem	der	dem	den (+ <i>-n on the noun</i>)

The single most useful observation: in the accusative, only the der-word changes. die and das sit still. That one asymmetry repeats everywhere — in pronouns, in possessives, in *kein*. Learn it once, and several other tables come free.

Indefinite articles follow the same shape:

	der-word	die-word	das-word
Nominative	ein	eine	ein
Accusative	einen	eine	ein
Dative	einem	einer	einem

2.2 What the cases actually mark

1. **Nominative** — the subject. Who or what is doing the verb.
2. **Accusative** — the direct object. What the verb is done *to*.
3. **Dative** — the indirect object. Who *receives* it.
4. **Genitive** — possession. Not yet covered.

Case is decided by **the noun's role in the sentence**. It is not a property of the verb's type — there is no such thing as an “accusative verb” versus a “dative verb” in general. *haben*, *sehen* and *geben* all take accusative direct objects.

2.3 When to use accusative

Accusative marks the direct object of a verb. Most “doing” verbs take one: *haben*, *sehen*, *essen*, *trinken*, *kaufen*, *lesen*, *nehmen*.

The test: ask *what is the verb doing something to?* A clear answer means that noun is accusative.

The one big exception is *sein*. “To be” doesn’t act on anything — it equates two things — so nouns after *sein* stay nominative:

- Das ist **mein** Hund. (*not meinen*)
- Ist das **dein** Hund? (*same reason — still a sein-sentence*)

Why this trips people: “Ist das deinen Hund?” feels right because *Hund* looks like an object. But nothing is being done to the dog; the sentence is just saying *that = your dog*. No action, no accusative.

Modal verbs change nothing here. The infinitive at the end decides the case, exactly as it would on its own:

- Ich möchte **den Hund** sehen. — *sehen* takes accusative, so *den Hund*.
- Ich kann schlafen. — *schlafen* takes no object at all.

2.4 Dative arrives by two separate routes

This is worth separating clearly, because the endings look identical but the reasons are unrelated.

Route 1 — the indirect object. The receiver, usually a person:

Ich gebe dem Mann ein Buch. *dem Mann* = dative (who receives) · *ein Buch* = accusative (what is given)

Route 2 — certain prepositions simply demand it, with no object role involved at all:

Er spielt mit mir. *mir* isn’t receiving anything. *mit* just forces dative. Full list in Part V.

2.5 Verbs that take dative and nothing else

A small group of verbs takes a **dative** object even though there is only one object, and even though English makes it look direct:

Verb	Correct	Not
helfen — to help	Ich helfe ihr .	Ich helfe sie
danken — to thank	Ich danke ihm .	Ich danke ihn
gehören — to belong to	Das Buch gehört mir .	gehört mich

Also in this family: *gefallen*, *antworten*.

Why it feels wrong: “I help her” looks like a plain direct object in English. German treats the helped person as a **recipient** of help, not a thing being acted on. Once you hear it as “I give help *to* her,” the dative stops feeling arbitrary.

The practical trap: it is easy to spot that these verbs *need* dative and still reach for the accusative pronoun by reflex. The forms you want are **mir**, **dir**, **ihm**, **ihr**, **uns**, **euch**,

ihnen — never mich, dich, ihn, sie.

PART III — PRONOUNS

3.1 The full table

Nominative	Accusative	Dative
ich — I	mich	mir
du — you	dich	dir
er — he	ihn	ihm
sie — she	sie	ihr
es — it	es	ihm
wir — we	uns	uns
ihr — you all	euch	euch
sie — they	sie	ihnen
Sie — you (formal)	Sie	Ihnen

Three things make this much smaller than it looks:

1. **Only four dative forms are genuinely new** — mir, dir, ihm, ihnen. *uns* and *euch* are identical in both object cases; *es* / *sie* / *Sie* carry over.
2. **er changes twice** — er -> ihn -> ihm, mirroring der -> den -> dem exactly. The same shape, so if the articles are solid these follow.
3. **es and sie barely move**. Both hold still in the accusative. Only the dative shifts them — and that is where the one real trap lives:

es -> ihm. sie -> ihr.

es shares its dative form with *er*, which is counter-intuitive enough that it is easy to over-apply and give **ihm** for both *es* and *sie*. If you remember one thing from this table, make it this line.

3.2 The three jobs of “ihr”

Form	Job	Example
ihr	“you all” — subject	Ihr habt ein Buch
ihr	“to her” — dative	Ich gebe ihr ein Buch
ihr / ihre	“her” — possessive	Ihre Katze ist müde
Ihr / Ihnen (<i>capital</i>)	formal “your” / “to you”	Ist das Ihr Buch?

Context resolves it, and usually the verb does the work: *ihr habt* can only be “you all”, because a dative *ihr* could never be the subject of *habt*.

3.3 The pronoun trap worth real attention

A German pronoun follows the noun’s grammatical gender — never the English meaning, never whether the thing is a person or an object.

Three steps, every time:

1. Find the noun being replaced.
2. Recall its article — der, die, or das.
3. Convert: der -> er / ihn · die -> sie / sie · das -> es / es

Sentence	Becomes	Why
Ich sehe den Tisch .	Ich sehe ihn .	der Tisch
Ich habe das Buch .	Ich habe es .	das Buch
Sie kauft die Milch .	Sie kauft sie .	die Milch
Ich esse einen Apfel .	Ich esse ihn .	der Apfel

Now the part that feels wrong and is correct anyway:

- **der Apfel** is an object, but takes **ihn** — literally “I eat him.”
- **das Kind** is a person, but takes **es** — “she sees it.”
- **das Mädchen** (girl) is also a das-word -> **es**.

English picks *it* or *him/her* based on whether something is a thing or a person. German does not make that distinction at all. When a German pronoun sounds wrong to an English ear, that is expected — it is not a signal that you have made a mistake.

Self-check that makes this automatic: before choosing a pronoun, say the noun *with its article* — “der Apfel” -> der -> ihn.

This has a useful consequence: if you cannot recall a noun’s article, you cannot choose its pronoun. That is the strongest practical argument for **always learning nouns together with der/die/das**. The article isn’t decoration; it is load-bearing information you will need repeatedly.

3.4 Possessives use the same endings

	der/das-word	die-word	plural
Nominative	mein Vater · unser Auto	meine Mutter	meine Eltern
Accusative	meinen Vater	meine Mutter	meine Eltern
Dative	meinem Vater	meiner Mutter	meinen Eltern

Identical pattern for dein-, sein-, ihr-, unser-, Ihr-.

The ending to be careful with: -en is DATIVE plural, not plural in general. This one is genuinely easy to over-generalise:

- mit **unseren** Eltern — dative, because *mit* forces it -> **-en**
- gegen **unsere** Eltern — accusative plural -> **no -en**

“Plural takes -en” is a tempting rule and a false one. The plural accusative leaves the possessive unmarked, exactly like the singular die-word form.

Note also that **neuter nominative stays bare**: *unser Auto*, not *unsere Auto* — same as *mein Buch*.

3.5 uns versus unser-

Two different words that look related:

- **uns** — pronoun, “us”: Er sieht **uns**.
- **unser-** — possessive, “our”: **unsere** Eltern, mit **unseren** Eltern

Same shape of confusion as *ihr* (you all) versus *ihre* (her). A pronoun and its look-alike possessive do different jobs and take different endings.

PART IV — NEGATION

4.1 Choosing between *nicht* and *kein*

kein negates a noun that would otherwise take *ein/eine* or no article at all — something indefinite or general:

- Ich habe **keinen** Hund. (*versus “einen Hund”*)
- Ich habe **keine** Zeit. (*Zeit normally takes no article*)

nicht negates everything else:

- a verb — Ich arbeite **nicht**.
- an adjective — Ich bin **nicht** müde.
- a **specific, definite** noun — Ich sehe den Hund **nicht**.

kein takes the same endings as *ein*: keinen Hund, keine Zeit, kein Buch.

The test: could the word be replaced with “no ____” naturally, as a general thing? -> *kein*. Is it a verb, an adjective, or a specific already-identified noun? -> *nicht*.

4.2 Why “*kein den Hund*” cannot exist

Because **kein** and **der/die/das** are alternatives, not stackable.

- **kein** replaces the article slot entirely. In *Ich habe keinen Hund* there is no separate *ein* — *kein* is the article.
- **nicht** doesn’t touch the article at all. In *Ich sehe den Hund nicht*, *den* stays exactly as it was and *nicht* sits separately, negating the action.

“*kein den Hund*” would put two articles on one noun.

So the real question is always: what was there originally? An *ein/eine* (or nothing) -> *kein* replaces it. A *der/die/das* -> keep it and add *nicht*.

4.3 Where *nicht* goes

***nicht* sits as late in the sentence as it can, but immediately before whatever it negates** — a verb, an infinitive, or a separable prefix:

- Ich sehe **nicht** fern.
- Er kann **nicht** schwimmen.
- Ich stehe um sieben Uhr **nicht** auf.

A definite object comes before *nicht*, because the object isn’t what’s being negated — it is established information:

- **Right:** Ich sehe **den Hund** **nicht**.
- **Right:** So kann er **den Hund** **nicht** sehen.

The logic is worth holding onto rather than memorising the order: you aren’t negating *the dog*, you’re negating *the seeing*. So *nicht* attaches to the verb, and the dog — already

known information — stays in front.

A shorter version of the same idea: *nicht* pushes as far right as it can, and a definite object gets out of its way.

“Ich sehe nicht den Hund” is not wrong — it is a different sentence. Putting *nicht* *before* the object makes it **contrastive**: it sets up a correction, and sounds unfinished without one.

Sentence	Meaning
Ich sehe den Hund nicht .	I don't see the dog. (<i>plain negation</i>)
Ich sehe nicht den Hund , sondern die Katze.	It's not the dog I see, but the cat.

Worth knowing as a tool rather than just avoiding — but for ordinary negation, the object goes first.

4.4 keine Zeit versus nicht viel Zeit

Not two ways of saying one thing:

- **Wir haben keine Zeit.** — no time at all.
- **Wir haben nicht viel Zeit.** — some time exists, just not much.

The second one uses *nicht* despite *Zeit* being a noun, because *nicht* is negating **viel** (the quantifier), not the noun. That is consistent with the rule in 4.1, not an exception to it.

PART V — PREPOSITIONS

5.1 Prepositions that always take dative

aus · außer · bei · mit · nach · seit · von · zu

Worth memorising as a rhythm — “*aus, außer, bei, mit, nach, seit, von, zu*” — because there is no logic to derive; membership in this list is the whole rule. Whatever follows goes into dative, regardless of its role:

mit dem Hund	bei der Arbeit
von der Arbeit	aus dem Haus
seit dem Jahr	zu meiner Mutter

The habit to guard against: dropping the article. *von Arbeit, nach Wochenende, von Schule* all feel acceptable because English drops articles freely (“from work”, “after the weekend”). German doesn't — a dative preposition keeps its article every time.

5.2 Prepositions that always take accusative

für · um · durch · gegen · ohne — the initials spell FUDGO.

- Das Buch ist **für dich**.
- Wir gehen **durch den** Park.
- Ich esse Brot **ohne** Milch.
- Wir spielen **gegen unsere** Eltern.
- Ich stehe **um** sieben Uhr auf.

5.3 Two-way prepositions

in · an · auf · über · unter · vor · hinter · neben · zwischen

These take *either* case. Which one is decided by a single question:

Ask	Meaning	Case
wohin? — where <i>to</i> ?	movement into/onto	accusative
wo? — where?	static location	dative

Movement (accusative)	Location (dative)
Ich gehe ins Zimmer.	Ich bin im Zimmer.
Ich gehe in den Garten.	Der Hund ist im Garten.
Er legt das Buch auf den Tisch.	Die Katze sitzt auf dem Tisch.

Contractions: in + das -> **ins** · in + dem -> **im** · an + das -> **ans** · an + dem -> **am**

Ignore the list of nine words. They all follow the one question, so the question is the only thing worth memorising. The usual difficulty isn't the concept — it's applying it at speed while also getting the noun's gender right (*der Garten* -> dem or den, never der). Both parts have to happen at once, which is why this takes practice rather than understanding.

A boundary worth being explicit about: *nach* is never used for moving into an enclosed space. Going into a room is **in den Raum**, not “nach dem Raum”. *nach* is for cities, countries, directions — and for “after” in time (below).

5.4 nach versus zu

Both can mean “to”. They split on whether the destination takes an article.

nach — destinations with **no** article: - Cities and countries: nach Berlin, nach München, nach Deutschland, nach Indien - Directions: nach links, nach oben - **And separately, “after” in time:** nach dem Wochenende, nach dem Termin

zu — destinations that **do** take an article: - People: zu meiner Mutter - Places: zur Schule, zum Bahnhof, zum Arzt, zur Post - Events: zur Arbeit

The test: does the destination normally come with der/die/das? No -> nach. Yes -> zu.

Contractions: zu + dem -> **zum** · zu + der -> **zur**

But possessives never contract. *zu meiner Mutter* stays spelled out — “zur Mutter” would mean “to the mother”, a different sentence. Contractions only ever happen with the bare article.

Both can appear in one sentence doing different jobs:

Wir gehen **nach dem Termin** (*after — time*) **zum Arzt** (*to — destination*).

Time before place — see Part VI.

Later complication, not needed yet: a few countries take an article and use in instead — in die Schweiz, in die USA.**

5.5 aus versus von — two kinds of “from”

- **aus** — out of an enclosed space, or origin/nationality Ich komme **aus** Indien. · Ich komme **aus dem** Haus.
- **von** — coming from a place you were at Sie kommt **von der** Arbeit. · Er kommt **von der** Schule.

Returning from work or school is *von*. Physically exiting a building is *aus*. The overlap is genuinely subtle and native speakers lean on feel.

5.6 Fixed phrases that ignore the rules

Some phrases are set expressions and don't decompose:

- **zu Hause** — “at home”. Not *zur Haus*, not *im Haus*.
- **an der Ecke** — “on the corner” (location). *an*, not *in*.
- **zur Ecke** — “to the corner” (destination).

PART VI — WORD ORDER

6.1 Verb-second — the backbone

The conjugated verb occupies the second position — second *slot*, not second *word*. Position one can hold an entire phrase.

Position 1	Position 2 — VERB	Rest
Ich	esse	heute einen Apfel
Heute	esse	ich einen Apfel
Am Wochenende	gehe	ich ins Kino
Weil ich müde bin,	bleibe	ich zu Hause

When something other than the subject takes position one, **the subject moves behind the verb**. The verb never moves.

Fronting changes emphasis, not just order. *Mein Vater arbeitet heute* foregrounds the father; *Heute arbeitet mein Vater* foregrounds the day. Both are correct — they answer different questions.

6.2 Yes/no questions — verb first

Verb and subject swap:

Statement	Question
Du bist müde.	Bist du müde?
Sie wohnt in Berlin.	Wohnt sie in Berlin?
Er kann schwimmen.	Kann er schwimmen?
Du hast Zeit.	Hast du Zeit?

6.3 W-questions — question word first, verb second

wer · was · wo · wohin · wann · warum · wie

Wo ist der Mann? · Was hast du? · Wie geht's dir?

6.4 weil sends the verb to the end — and the main clause still needs V2

Two rules apply at once here, which is what makes this construction genuinely tricky.

First: *weil* pushes its own clause's verb to the very end.

Weil ich müde **bin**, ... · Weil es **regnet**, ...

Second: the main clause that follows still needs verb-second — because the entire *weil*-clause counts as position one:

Weil es regnet, bleibe ich zu Hause.

position 1 = the whole clause · position 2 = *bleibe* · subject third

Getting one half right and the other wrong is the usual outcome. Both have to hold simultaneously.

denn also means “because” but behaves completely differently. It is a coordinating conjunction, like *und/aber/oder*, so word order stays normal in both halves:

Ich bleibe zu Hause, **denn ich bin** müde.

6.5 Time — Manner — Place

After the verb, elements line up **time -> manner -> place**:

Ich gehe **heute** (*time*) **mit meiner Mutter** (*manner*) **nach Berlin** (*place*).

Time words sit right after the conjugated verb: *Ich muss heute schlafen*.

This is the reverse of English, which tends to put place before time (“I’m going to Berlin today”). It is why *Wir gehen nach dem Termin zum Arzt* puts the appointment before the doctor.

6.6 Separable verbs

In an ordinary present-tense sentence, the **prefix detaches and goes to the very end**:

Verb	In a sentence
aufstehen	Ich stehe um sieben Uhr auf .
anrufen	Ich rufe dich an .
fernsehen	Ich sehe gern fern .

With a modal verb it does not split — the whole infinitive goes to the end intact:

Ich muss um sieben Uhr **aufstehen**.

With nicht, the negation sits immediately before the prefix:

Ich stehe um sieben Uhr **nicht auf**.

PART VII — BEYOND THE PRESENT TENSE

7.1 Modal verbs

	können (can)	müssen (must)	möchten (would like)
ich	kann	muss	möchte
du	kannst	musst	möchtest

	können (can)	müssen (must)	möchten (would like)
er/sie/es	kann	muss	möchte
wir	können	müssen	möchten
ihr	könnt	müsst	möchtet
sie/Sie	können	müssen	möchten

Structure: the modal conjugates and takes position two; the second verb goes to the very end in **plain infinitive form**.

Ich **muss** heute **schlafen**. · **Kann** er **schwimmen**?

Note that ich and er/sie/es are identical in all three — unusual, and worth noticing because it removes a conjugation decision rather than adding one.

7.2 The imperative

Addressing	How it's formed	Example
du	drop the -st	du gibst -> Gib mir das Buch!
ihr	plain ihr-form, drop the pronoun	ihr esst -> Esst das Brot!
Sie	infinitive + Sie , verb first	Kommen Sie herein!

Two details about stem changes:

- **e -> i/ie changes are kept:** geben -> **Gib!** · sehen -> **Sieh!**
- **umlaut changes are dropped:** fahren -> **Fahr!** (*not Fähr*)

The Sie-form keeps its pronoun. “Kommen herein” is incomplete — German doesn't drop *Sie* the way English drops “you” in commands.

Object cases work exactly as they always do: *Gib mir das Buch* — *mir* dative (receiver), *das Buch* accusative (thing given). The imperative changes the verb form and nothing else.

7.3 Perfekt — the past tense of conversation

Structure: helper verb (**haben** or **sein**, conjugated, position two) + **past participle at the very end**.

Ich **habe** gestern Fußball **gespielt**. Ich **bin** ins Kino **gegangen**.

The shape should feel familiar — it is the same “conjugated verb second, other verb thrown to the end” pattern as modal verbs and separable verbs.

Choosing **haben** or **sein**

sein is used for: - **movement from one place to another** — gehen, kommen, fahren, fliegen, laufen - **change of state** — aufstehen, einschlafen, sterben, werden - **two exceptions to memorise** — *sein* itself (ich bin gewesen) and *bleiben* (ich bin geblieben)

haben covers everything else — which is the large majority.

The test: does the verb describe moving between two places, or a genuine change of state? -> sein. Otherwise -> haben.

Where intuition misleads: *stehen* feels physical, but standing still isn't going anywhere -> **haben**. *spielen* is energetic but involves no destination -> **haben**. Meanwhile *bleiben* means staying put and takes **sein** anyway, purely as an exception.

Building the participle

- **Regular (weak):** ge + stem + t *machen* -> **gemacht** · *spielen* -> **gespielt** · *kaufen* -> **gekauft**
- **Irregular (strong):** ge + (often altered) stem + **en** — no rule, memorised per verb, exactly like English *go* -> *went*.
- **Separable verbs:** the *ge-* goes **between prefix and stem** *einschlafen* -> **ein·ge·schlafen** · *aufstehen* -> **auf·ge·standen**

The irregular participles covered so far

Verb	Participle	Helper
gehen	gegangen (<i>e->a</i>)	sein
kommen	gekommen	sein
fahren	gefahren (<i>no umlaut</i>)	sein
fliegen	geflogen	sein
bleiben	geblieben	sein
einschlafen	eingeschlafen	sein
sehen	gesehen	haben
lesen	gelesen	haben
essen	gegessen	haben
trinken	getrunken	haben
stehen	gestanden	haben

Three specific traps in that table: *fahren* has an umlaut in the present tense (*er fährt*) but **none** in the participle — *gefahren*. *bleiben* looks like it should take the regular -t and doesn't. And separable verbs hide the *ge-* in the middle, where it is easy to miss.

Two systems that are often confused, and shouldn't be

Choosing **haben/sein** and spelling the participle are completely independent questions. There is no correlation whatsoever:

Verb	Regular?	Helper
gehen	irregular	sein
arbeiten	regular	haben
bleiben	irregular	sein
kaufen	regular	haben
kommen	irregular	sein

"Irregular verbs take sein" is a tempting shortcut and simply false. The helper depends on **meaning** (motion or state-change). The participle spelling depends on **memorisation**. Neither predicts the other.

7.4 Stem-changing verbs in the present

Some verbs shift their stem vowel in the **du** and **er/sie/es** forms — and nowhere else:

Verb	du	er / sie / es
essen	isst	isst
sehen	siehst	sieht
lesen	liest	liest
geben	gibst	gibt
helfen	hilfst	hilft
schlafen	schläfst	schläft
tragen	trägst	trägt
fahren	fährst	fährt

The **ich** form never changes. *ich esse, ich sehe, ich helfe, ich gebe.* Reaching for “*ich hilfe*” is over-applying a change that belongs only to *du* and *er*.

7.5 leben versus wohnen

- **wohnen** — to reside, to have an address: *Ich wohne in Würzburg.*
- **leben** — to be alive, a way of life, or living *with* people: *Er lebt mit seiner Mutter.*

An address question takes *wohnen*. Living *with* someone, or life in general, takes *leben*.

7.6 mögen versus gern

- **mögen** pairs with a **noun** — *Ich mag Musik.*
- **gern** pairs with a **verb** — *Ich lese gern.* · *Ich sehe gern fern.*

“*Ich mag kochen*” is the natural English-shaped guess and the wrong one. To like *doing* something, use **gern** + the verb: *Ich koche gern.*

7.7 geben — the double-object verb

Ich gebe dem Mann ein Buch. *dem Mann* dative (receiver) · *ein Buch* accusative (thing)

When both objects are nouns, **dative comes first**.

Don’t add *zu*. The dative already carries “to”: *Er gibt seiner Mutter das Buch*, not “*gibt das Buch zu seiner Mutter.*”

Also worth keeping apart by sound: **geben** (to give) and **gehen** (to go) are easy to swap when writing quickly.

PART VIII — VOCABULARY

8.1 Greetings and everyday phrases

German	English
Hallo	hello
Guten Morgen / Tag / Abend	good morning / day / evening
Gute Nacht	good night
Tschüss	bye (informal)

German	English
Auf Wiedersehen	goodbye (formal)
Bis später · bis bald	see you later · see you soon
Wie geht's?	how's it going?
Mir geht's gut	I'm doing well
Entschuldigung	excuse me · sorry
bitte	please
danke	thank you
kein Problem	no problem
noch mal	again · one more time
Gute Reise	have a good trip
Mach's gut	take care

It is **Guten** Morgen — a fixed accusative-shaped phrase, never “Guter”.

8.2 People and family

der Mann (*Männer*) · die Frau (*Frauen*) · das Kind (*Kinder*) · die Familie · die Mutter (*Mütter*) · der Vater (*Väter*) · die Eltern (*plural only*) · der Bruder (*Brüder*) · die Schwester (*Schwestern*) · der Freund (*Freunde*)

8.3 Food and drink

das Brot · das Hähnchen · der Reis · die Suppe · der Käse · die Milch · der Apfel (*Äpfel*) · das Wasser · **essen** (*isst*) · **trinken**

Äpfel is the plural — the singular is plain **Apfel**, with no umlaut.

8.4 House and rooms

das Haus (*Häuser*) · das Zimmer (*unchanged in plural*) · der Raum (*Räume*) · die Küche · das Schlafzimmer · das Bad · der Tisch (*Tische*) · der Stuhl (*Stühle*) · das Fenster (*unchanged*) · der Garten (*Gärten*)

der **Tisch** is the table, der **Stuhl** is the chair.

Compound nouns take the gender of their last part: schlafen + das Zimmer = **das** Schlafzimmer.

8.5 Getting around town

der Bus (*Busse*) · die Bahn · der Zug · die Straße (*Straßen*) · die Ampel (*Ampeln*) · die Ecke (*Ecken*) · **rechts** · **links** · **geradeaus** · die Bank (*Banken*) · der Park · das Rathaus · die Post · das Kino · das Geschäft · der Bahnhof · die Schule

Useful phrases: **an der Ecke** · **zur Post** · **zum Bahnhof** · **ins Zentrum**

8.6 Time and daily routine

die Zeit · die Uhr · **heute** · **morgen** (*tomorrow*) · **der Morgen** (*the morning*) · das Wochenende · der Termin · **aufstehen** (*separable*) · **arbeiten** · **schlafen** (*schläft*) · **wohnen** · **leben** · **um** (*at, for clock times*)

Note **morgen** (*tomorrow*) versus **der Morgen** (*the morning*) — identical but for the capital.

8.7 Weather

das Wetter · die Sonne · der Regen · **kalt** · **warm** · **regnen** (*impersonal — es regnet*)

8.8 Hobbies

das Hobby (*Hobbys*) · **lesen** (*liest*) · **spielen** · **schwimmen** · die Musik · **gern** · **fernsehen** (*sehe fern*) · **mögen** (*mag*) · das Fernsehen (*the noun*)

8.9 Clothing and colours

das T-Shirt · die Hose · das Kleid · die Jacke · der Schuh (*Schuhe*) · **tragen** (*trägt*) · **blau** · **rot** · **grün** · **schwarz**

8.10 Shopping and money

das Geld · der Preis · **kaufen** · **kosten** · **teuer** · **billig** · die Tasche (*Taschen*)

8.11 Adjectives and adverbs

müde · glücklich · hungrig · gut · schön · lang · neu

Frequency: **immer** (*always*) · **oft** (*often*) · **manchmal** (*sometimes*) · **selten** (*rarely*) · **nie** (*never*)

8.12 Question words

wer (*who*) · was (*what*) · wo (*where*) · wohin (*where to*) · wann (*when*) · warum (*why*) · wie (*how*)

8.13 Conjunctions

und · **aber** · **oder** · **denn** — all keep normal word order **weil** — sends the verb to the end of its clause

8.14 Numbers 1–20

eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf, sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn, elf, zwölf, dreizehn, vierzehn, fünfzehn, sechzehn, siebzehn, achtzehn, neunzehn, zwanzig

With a number, the article disappears: **zwei Hunde**, never “zweinen Hunde”.

PART IX — THE TRAPS

Every item here is a mistake that is easy to make, hard to notice, and worth pre-empting. Grouped by why they happen.

9.1 Traps created by English

English habits that produce fluent-sounding, wrong German:

The instinct	What German needs
“I help her” -> object	helfen takes dative — <i>Ich helfe ihr</i>
“it” for things, “him” for people	Gender decides: <i>der Apfel</i> -> ihn , <i>das Kind</i> -> es
“I like cooking”	gern + verb, not mögen — <i>Ich koche gern</i>
“from work” — drop the article	Dative prepositions keep it — <i>von der Arbeit</i>
“to Berlin” / “to the doctor” — one word	nach Berlin (<i>no article</i>) vs zum Arzt (<i>has one</i>)
“I’m going to Berlin today” — place, then time	German is time , then place
“Is that your dog?” — feels like an object	<i>sein</i> never takes accusative — <i>dein Hund</i>

Also worth guarding against: writing *Munich* rather than *München*, and reaching for an English word mid-sentence when the German one won’t come.

When a word won't come, write ??? rather than the English. What you couldn't retrieve is the most useful information in the whole exercise — substituting English hides it.

9.2 Traps created by over-applying a real rule

These are the hardest to unlearn, because the rule is genuinely correct somewhere else:

Over-application	The boundary
-en marks plural	It marks dative plural. <i>gegen unsere Eltern</i> takes no -en
Umlauts in plurals -> umlauts everywhere	Singular stays plain: <i>Apfel, Stuhl, Brot</i> . And <i>gefahren</i> has none despite <i>er fährt</i>
Stem changes apply throughout	Only du and er/sie/es. <i>ich helfe</i> , never “ich hilfe”
Accusative for objects es and er share ihm, so sie must too	Not after <i>sein</i> , and not for dative-only verbs sie -> ihr . This is the single most slippery cell in the pronoun table
Nouns are capitalized	But not infinitives or separable prefixes: <i>sehe fern, kann schwimmen</i>
ge- goes at the front of a participle	Separable verbs put it in the middle: <i>eingeschlafen</i>

9.3 Plausible rules that are simply false

Four shortcuts that feel like they should work and don't:

1. **“Accusative is for action verbs, dative for non-action verbs.”** Case comes from the noun's *role*, not the verb's character.
2. **“Plural always takes -en.”** Dative plural does. Accusative plural doesn't.
3. **“Irregular verbs use sein in the Perfekt.”** Entirely unrelated systems — *arbeiten* is regular and takes *haben*; *bleiben* is irregular and takes *sein*.
4. **“nach is for nouns in infinitive form.”** Nouns don't have infinitives. The real split is article versus no article.

9.4 Small forms that are easy to lose

Things that vanish under concentration:

- **The article after a dative preposition** — *von der Arbeit*
- **The pronoun in a Sie-imperative** — *Kommen Sie herein*
- **The -e on a feminine possessive** — *Ihre Katze*
- **The umlaut in möchte** — *Möchtest du...*
- **ist, not “is”** — English spelling leaking into German
- **du forms** — *hast*, not *habt*; *bist*, not *seid*

9.5 Words that sit too close together

Pair	Difference
geben / gehen	to give / to go
Tisch / Stuhl	table / chair

Pair	Difference
morgen / der Morgen	tomorrow / the morning
leben / wohnen	to be alive, live with / to reside at an address
aus / von	out of an enclosed space / back from a place you were
an der Ecke / zur Ecke	at the corner / to the corner
uns / unser-	us (<i>pronoun</i>) / our (<i>possessive</i>)
ihr / ihre / Ihr	you all / her / your (formal)

9.6 Where errors actually come from

Worth knowing, because it changes how to practise: most mistakes here are **not** knowledge gaps. The same forms that come out correctly in a focused drill break under load — while producing free sentences, while juggling a new structure, while speaking in real time.

Two consequences:

- **Isolated drilling can be misleading.** Something that passes every isolated test can still fail in free production. Mixed practice, where attention is divided, is the more honest test.
- **A fast flawed answer teaches more than a slow careful one.** Errors that only appear at speed are exactly the errors that appear in conversation.

PART X — HOW TO STUDY THIS

10.1 Memory hooks

Hook	Covers
FUDGO	für, um, durch, gegen, ohne — the accusative prepositions
<i>aus, außer, bei, mit, nach, seit, von, zu</i>	the dative prepositions — say it as a rhythm
wohin? / wo?	two-way prepositions — the only thing worth memorising
der -> den -> dem <i>mirrors</i> er -> ihn -> ihm	articles and pronouns are one pattern
Say the noun <i>with</i> its article	der Apfel -> der -> ihn
es -> ihm, sie -> ihr	the pronoun cell most likely to go wrong

10.2 Principles worth following

- **Nothing counts as learned until it survives a night.** A clean first attempt measures comprehension, not retention.
- **Two new grammar concepts a week.** Extra study time should buy depth, not more topics.
- **Every new word gets used in a sentence the same day.** Recognition and production are different skills.
- **Retrieval beats review.** Producing from memory beats re-reading, every time.
- **Learn nouns with their articles, always.** Without the article you can't form the pronoun, the accusative, or the dative.

10.3 Writing and speaking test different things

	Writing shows	Speaking shows
Conjugation and case endings	yes	no
Spelling and umlauts	yes	no
Word order	yes	yes
Retrieval speed	no	yes
Automaticity	no	yes

Learn in writing, prove in speech. Writing is where endings can actually be checked; speaking is where you find out what has become automatic. A form can be solid in one and shaky in the other — that isn't a contradiction, it's the two skills separating.

10.4 What to work on next

1. **weil** — verb last inside the clause, verb second in the main clause. The two halves have a habit of failing in alternation: get one right, lose the other. Practise them **together in one sentence**, not separately — each half alone is already understood.
2. **Dative-only verbs** — helfen, danken, gehören with mir / dir / ihm / ihr. The concept is secure; it's the pronoun form that slips.
3. **es -> ihm versus sie -> ihr**
4. **nicht with a definite object** — object first, nicht at the end
5. **Perfekt participles** — pure memorisation, no shortcut exists
6. **aus versus von**

Recently cleared: two-way prepositions (5/5 with reasoning, after four passes) and the unsere/unseren accusative-plural ending.

QUICK REFERENCE

Articles der · den · dem — die · die · der — das · das · dem — *plural*: die · die · den +n

Pronouns ich–mich–mir · du–dich–dir · er–ihn–ihm · sie–sie–**ihr** · es–es–**ihm** wir–uns–uns · ihr–euch–euch · sie–sie–ihnen · Sie–Sie–Ihnen

Prepositions *Dative*: aus, außer, bei, mit, nach, seit, von, zu *Accusative*: für, um, durch, gegen, ohne
(FUDGO) *Two-way*: in, an, auf, über, unter, vor, hinter, neben, zwischen -> **wohin?** = accusative · **wo?** = dative

Contractions ins · im · ans · am · zum · zur · vom — **never with a possessive**

Word order Verb second · yes/no questions verb first · *weil* verb last · time -> manner -> place · separable prefix to the end · *nicht* immediately before what it negates

Perfekt haben/sein + participle at the end *sein* = motion or change of state, plus sein and bleiben
haben = everything else

This document is regenerated as the material grows — the .tex and .pdf versions are built from this file by build_notes.sh, so edit the Markdown rather than the generated copies.